Careless Love

By John Olive

INTRODUCTION

Actor #1 (F): Abortion is one of the most divisive issues in modern US history, perhaps even more so than homosexuality. The sharp divisions cut through politics, religion and even families themselves.

Actor #2 (M): Mother Teresa once said: It is a poverty to decide that a child must die so that you may live as you wish. The choice to abort, however, is never an easy one. The mother must deal with feelings of guilt. The choice will burden her conscience in life; it will burden her soul in death.

Actor #1 (F): The mother? The mother? Why is the father exempt from responsibility in the decision? Listen closely as Martha and Jack attempt to resolve this issue in

Actor #2 (M): Careless Love by John Olive

JACK: (slightly startled) Oh, hi. I thought you weren't coming.

MARTHA: Birthday party started drinking champagne, and, well, you know...

JACK: Champagne drinkers.

MARTHA: Yeah.

JACK: Animals. (short beat) Well, I'm glad you came. Sit down.

MARTHA: Well, okay. (SHE sits, and takes the script, opens it.) This the new play?

JACK: Yeah.

MARTHA: "Little Criminals." (pages through the script) Which are you?

JACK: Andrew.

MARTHA: (reads) "Gone to seed attorney. Less intelligent than he thinks. Drinks." (starts paging through the script)

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JACK: (watches her for a short moment) The first act is very weak. I'm not in it. (pauses) Page forty eight. (MARTHA reads.) I could recite it.

MARTHA: No.

JACK: Want a beer? (reads from a card on the table) Molson, Moosehead, Dab, Harp, Guiness, Bass, Dos Equis, Carta Blanca and please stop me,

MARTHA: No, thanks, Jack, I don't want any beer.

JACK: Okay. (reads again) Inglenook, Blue Nun, Gallo. Marty.

MARTHA: Nothing.

JACK: Perrier? Virgin Mary? Coke?

MARTHA: Nothing.

(Beat. MARTHA continues to read. JACK gently takes the script from her hands, and sets it aside. MARTHA looks away; suddenly, looks lonely, upset.)

JACK: Are you okay, Marty?

MARTHA: I'm fine.

JACK: Are you...sick at all? In the mornings or something?

MARTHA: Little bit. Mainly, I'm tired.

JACK: Do you feel like there's really something...I don't know, weird, going on with your body? Something basic?

MARTHA: I'm pregnant.

JACK: Oh, okay, right. (takes a pull of his beer) How 'bout those Cubbies? (beat) Marty. I'm sorry about the other day, if I behaved badly.

MARTHA: When?

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JACK: The other day. At the theater. You remember the little scene at the theater?

MARTHA: Scene?

JACK: Well, whatever you want to call it, it was a scene. The folks at rehearsal were all moved.

MARTHA: You're a very good actor.

JACK: (stares at her, shocked, then laughs) Look, this is hard. I mean, normally this is something that happens between people who know each other pretty well.

MARTHA: I'm sorry this is hard for you.

JACK: Do you really hate me?

MARTHA: Not at all. You were a very good lover.

JACK: (after a slight pause) Okay. Do you need some money?

MARTHA: Money?

JACK: For...an abortion? All I wanna do is whatever's the right thing. (quick beat) You know Stuart, the guy I was talking to at rehearsal when you came in? After you...left, he said, "Well, Jack, are you going to do the right thing by that girl?" And I said, "Marry her?" He looks at me, big dramatic pause, and says, "Pay for her abortion!"
(pause) Well, anyway, do you need some money? I...got my checkbook.

MARTHA: (not looking at JACK) I made an appointment today, at Planned Parenthood.

JACK: Oh? They have abortions there? It's not just...pills and rubbers?

MARTHA: They have referrals to abortionists. They send you someplace else, to get the abortion. All they do is, they advise you.

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JACK: (after a slight pause) When's the-?

MARTHA: (overlapping JACK) And if you need- (stops)

JACK: Go ahead.

MARTHA: And if you need money or something, they can advise you about that.

JACK: Well, I can pay for... I can help you pay for the --

MARTHA: It happens really fast. They stretch your vagina open, with a...thing. Then there's this long needle, they showed me one, they use it to inject Novacaine into your cervix. That part hurts. Then they stretch your cervix open, and then they.. .suck the baby out, with a vacuum. Then they scrape the rest of it out, then they suck it all clean, and that's it. Easy. (pauses) Then you have a lot of emotional problems afterwards, lots of...anxiety, because of all the... Well, I guess you lose a lot of hormones.

JACK: Do you want me to go down there with you? (MARTHA laughs, abruptly and rather shrilly.) What's so funny?

MARTHA: That's not what you're supposed to say!

JACK: Tell me what I'm supposed to say! Tell me what to do! This is hard! You feel like a total stranger to me, and you wouldn't believe the load of Irish Catholic guilt I'm carrying about this.

MARTHA: You get guilty, I get pregnant.

JACK: (Now JACK bursts out laughing. Then an abrupt beat: He covers his face with his hands, weeping. Finally:) Well, @#$% you. You have as much responsibility in this as I do.

MARTHA: I don't expect anything from you. If all you want is for this to be over, then okay, it's over. I won't bother you any more. The guilt is

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your problem, I'm sure you can take care of that alone, I'm sure you've had lots of practice.

JACK: (staring at her) Jesus Christ.

MARTHA: I only told you because I thought you had a right to know.

JACK: As the father.

MARTHA: Yes.

JACK: You know, Marty, I was given to understand that your sex life was pretty varied and active, as they say.

MARTHA: Who gave you to understand that?

JACK: Persons who would, at this point, I'm sure, prefer to remain anonymous.

MARTHA: Well, they were wrong! You're the first person I've made love with since I left school.

JACK: Since...?

MARTHA: Almost three years.

JACK: That's great! Luck'o the Irish, eh? Your first time out in three years and you get zapped!

MARTHA: I'm not Irish.

JACK: But I am! (stands abruptly) Well, you're not getting @#$% from me, the price of an abortion, and that's it. (brandishes his script) I got work to do! Gotta go fake my way through another piece of @#$% play, the ole crazed Celtic charm strikes again. I should thank you, I'll be able to use all this in Act Three! (starts to exit, then turns, in a fake-theatrical voice) Good-bye, darling!

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